SCOUTING REPORT: MAIK AFRI AKUMU– HERTHA BERLIN U17 (DFB-NACHWUCHSLIGA)

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A) Player Information (Source: transfermarkt.de)

Name: Maik Afri Akumu

Club: Hertha Berlin U17

Nationality: Germany / Poland

Age: 16 (Date of Birth: 03.07.2008)

Position: Left Winger

Height: 1,84m

Strong foot: Right

Transfermarkt.de link: https://www.transfermarkt.de/maik-afri-akumu/profil/spieler/1167483

Season Performance:

Season	League / Division	Club	Games	Goals	Assists
24/25*	U17 Nachwuchsliga	Hertha Berlin U17	8	6	N/A

***Current season** (Last Season: 20.10.2024)

The player was scouted in the following games:

1) 21.09.2024 Hertha Berlin U17 – Holstein Kiel U17: 5-2 / U17 Nachwuchsliga (80 minutes)
2) 19.10.2024 Hertha Berlin U17 – St. Pauli U17: 3-0 / U17 Nachwuchsliga (80 minutes)

B) Report:

Team formation and player's role in team strategy: Hertha Berlin U17 plays in a 4-3-3 formation like their first team in 2. Bundesliga, and Afri Akumu plays in the left winger position. During attacks with buildup phase, he stays close to the left sideline in opponent's half; providing width for the attack setup. His teammates frequently try to find him as he has the ability to carry the ball to the final third with dribbles. If the left back is carrying the ball forward, he cuts inside the left half-space to receive the ball in a dangerous position. He poses a threat both with his runs with the ball inside the opponent's penalty area and his shots with right foot from the left half-space as an inverted winger. Hertha Berlin uses a 4-1-3-2 formation to press the opponent, Afri Akumu presses the opponent's right central defender or right back, depending on the opponent's build-up play. When the opponent is pressing Hertha, he sometimes moves into the center to receive the ball directly from the defenders and run forward with the ball. He is strong in duels and does not give away the ball easily while carrying the ball.

During Hertha’s corners and set pieces won in the opponent's final third, he is positioned at the far post inside the opponent’s penalty area. He doesn’t go into aerial duels often. When defending set pieces and corners, he waits at the edge of the six-yard box that is closer to the flank that the corner is being taken.

Hertha Berlin U17’s Formation against St. Pauli U17

Game Notes

Afri Akumu frequently attemps to dribble past his opponent in the final third. His dribbling is very effective, and he holds his ground well in duels. He definitely is the player who forces to enter the opponent’s penalty area the most, trying to break the opponent’s defensive line and create shot or pass oppotunitites. His decision making is not his best skill, he sometimes loses the ball with a misplaced pass in assist opportunities, sometimes the ball goes out of play while he tries to pass his opponent. He carried the ball from the left to the penalty area in a 3-on-3 transition attack, but his low pass to the center was inaccurate. However, he constantly poses a threat to opponents and was clearly the difference maker in Hertha Berlin’s attacks. During the game against St. Pauli U17, he won a penalty inside the box. After entering the box, his shot was off target, but he managed to recover the ball after the goalkeeper's save and won a penalty following a challenge. In a 10-minute interval he found another one-on-one situation against the

goalkeeper in a counter-attack. He went past the keeper, who then fouled him, resulting in a red card for the goalkeeper. After that he took the free kick himself and scored from it.

He is the kind of player who makes a difference in one-on-one situations and has plenty of skills to create a threat to opponents. He has the ability to break set defenses and he can create himself corridors both by running near the sideline and by cutting in the left half-space. St. Pauli played in a 4-2-3-1 formation and the opponent's central midfielder tried to double team him in the left flank, but couldn't reduce his impact. His connections and plays with the left-back, also worked well. During build-up play, he moved inside and made a run from the center after receiving the ball, he got past his opponents, and despite being pulled by his shirt, he managed to pass the ball. In another situation, Arif Akumu made a run from the left wing toward the box, and just before reaching the edge of the box, his powerful shot went over the bar. In transition from attack to defense, he helped his full-back by intercepting a pass and returned the ball to the goalkeeper before repositioning himself.

Assessment

Afri Akumu is the most talented attacking player of Hertha Berlin's 2008 generation. He has a physical advantage against the players of his generation and his physical qualities also hint that he will sign his first professional contract within 2 years. The player has the potential to have a long career at the Bundesliga level. His most prominent skill is his dribbling and pace with the ball; and he is an ideal candidate for teams who play for the title, as he has the ability to break the defensive lines as an inverted winger and his shot quality is good. He also poses a threat to opponents in transition play. He unfortunately makes a lot of poor decisions in the penalty area; he especially needs to improve his final passes to create the same level of threat to the opponents in professional leagues. He contributes defensively to the team as well, but this has to be evaluated against a team with better attacking potential. St. Pauli was not at the level to test his abilities for defensive contribution. He is not far away from playing at the Süper Lig level and considering the fact that Beşiktaş lacks depth at the left-wing position, he is a good prospect for the end of the season. If he is to be considered as an option, he can be loaned to lower professional leagues for 1-2 seasons so that he can improve his decision making.